International programme admissions assessment: guide for staff

This pack assesses students applying to the international programme from **Year 1 to Year 10**, most of them joining from **Chinese mainstream schools** or **other bilingual schools**. It finds out four things:

1. **The student's level of English** in listening, speaking, reading and writing, because every lesson in the programme is taught in English.
2. **Their maths**, through number problems, word problems and problems with diagrams and pictures, and from Year 5 their **science**.
3. **Who they are**: interests, learning habits, wellbeing, and their **future plans and aspirations**.
4. **Suitability**: whether the programme is right for the student and the family, and what support the student will need from the first day.

Each candidate's assessment takes **about 45 minutes in Year 1 to about 70 minutes in Year 10**, plus a 15-minute conversation with the parents.

1. Principles

- **Accessible.** Clear layouts, large type, pictures and diagrams, short sentences, worked examples, easy questions first. Nobody should fail to show what they know because a page was confusing.
- **English only.** The papers are in English, because the English level is one of the things being measured. In maths and science, questions may be read aloud, so that a reading difficulty does not hide what a student can do (Section 7).
- **Fair to students from Chinese schools.** Chinese schools teach topics in a different order, so a student may not yet have met something the UK curriculum covers earlier. Assessors mark these "not yet taught" (NT) and judge what the student will do once taught (Section 8).
- **A profile, not a pass mark.** The result is a set of bands that describe the student and point to the support they need. The decision is a professional judgement made from the whole picture (Section 9).
- **Kind.** Students are told the aim is to get to know them. Any student may stop a section when they have done what they can. A distressed child is never pressed.

2. What is in the pack

Part	Files	Who uses it
This guide	`00_Admissions_Guide`	All staff
Reading books list	`01_Reading_Books_and_Materials`	Admissions, Years 1 to 3 assessors
Year group papers	`Y01` to `Y10`: a student booklet (Years 1 to 3) or student paper (Years 4 to 10), and an assessor booklet	Assessor
Early Reading Screen (Years 1 to 3, and older students new to English)	`shared/Early_Reading_Screen_Cards` (child reads from them; laminate), `shared/Early_Reading_Screen_Guide` (instructions; print once) and `shared/Early_Reading_Screen_Record` (record sheets; one set per child)	Assessor
Graded Sentence Reading Screen (all years)	`shared/Sentence_Reading_Card` (laminate) and `shared/Sentence_Reading_Record` (one per student)	Assessor or interviewer
Interview and suitability records	`forms/Interview_Record_Y1_Y2`, `_Y3_Y4`, `_Y5_Y6`, `_Y7_Y10`	Interviewer
Parent conversation	`forms/Parent_Conversation_Record`	Admissions or a senior teacher

Part	Files	Who uses it
Previous homeroom teacher reference (English and Chinese)	`forms/Homeroom_Teacher_Reference`	Admissions
Candidate summary and decision	`forms/Candidate_Summary_and_Decision`	Assessor, head of section, admissions

3. Roles

Role	Responsibilities
Admissions officer	Collects documents and consent, books the visit, sends the homeroom teacher reference, prints the pack, welcomes the family, communicates the decision.
Assessor (a teacher; for the English tasks ideally one with English as an additional language experience)	Runs the tasks, marks them the same day, completes the score summary.
Interviewer (often the assessor, or the head of section)	Runs the sentence reading screen and the interview.
Chinese-speaking colleague (optional)	Leads or interprets the parent conversation; may give the one-time Chinese reading of a maths or science question (Section 7); observes a young child's Chinese.
Receiving homeroom teacher (optional)	Meets the student, adds first impressions and a welcome plan to the interview record.
Head of section	Moderates, makes or confirms the recommendation.
Designated Safeguarding Lead	Receives any safeguarding information the same day, from the interview, the parent conversation or the reference.

4. The process

Before the visit

- Collect: the application, passport or ID page, school reports for the last two years, any assessment or medical reports, information about the student's registration (学籍), and signed consent to contact the current school.
- Send the homeroom teacher reference (`forms/Homeroom_Teacher_Reference`) once consent is given.
- Book the visit. Mornings are best for young children. Tell the family how long it will take, that the child should bring glasses or hearing aids if used, and ask about any access needs.
- Print the pack (Section 12) and set up a quiet, bright room with a low table for young children.

On the day

- Welcome the family together; show the child the room; let a young child see where the parent will wait.
- Run the tasks in the order in Section 5. The parent conversation happens at the same time, with another member of staff, or straight after.
- **Safeguarding:** a young child is never alone with one adult behind a closed door; keep doors open or two adults present. Anything worrying goes to the Designated Safeguarding Lead the same day.
- Thank the student. Do not give results on the day.

After the visit

- Mark everything the same day and complete the score summary in the assessor booklet.
- Complete the Candidate Summary and Decision within two working days.
- The head of section moderates and confirms the recommendation; admissions communicates it.

- Keep all papers securely (Section 11).

5. Timings by year group

Student time, in minutes. The order on the day is in each assessor booklet.

Year	Picture talk	Listening	Reading screens	Reading paper	Writing	Maths	Science	Interview (with sentence reading from Year 4)	Total
1	4	4	12 to 15		5	12		6	about 45 to 50
2	4	4	12 to 15		6	15		6	about 47 to 50
3	4	5	12 to 15		8	18		8	about 55 to 58
4		5		12	10	18		12	about 57
5 and 6		5		12	10	18	8	12	about 65
7 to 10		5		12	10	20	8	15	about 70

Reading screens in Years 1 to 3: the Early Reading Screen takes up to 10 to 12 minutes and the sentence reading screen 2 to 4 minutes for most young children; the start points and stopping rules keep most children inside this. Parent conversation: about 15 minutes. Breaks: a short movement break in Years 1 and 2; a 3 to 5 minute break after the written English from Year 3. From Year 4 the written papers can be taken in a small group with one invigilator (listening is read to the group); the interview is always 1:1.

6. The English proficiency bands

Every candidate gets a band for each of the four skills on this five-point scale, which is widely used for learners of English as an additional language. **Band E means "comparable to a fluent English speaker of the same age"**, so the same letter means something different for a 6 year old and a 14 year old. The year group booklets turn listening and reading scores into bands; writing and speaking are banded with these descriptors.

Band	Listening	Speaking	Reading	Writing
A New to English	Understands little or no English; may follow a routine instruction with gesture.	Silent, or single words and memorised phrases; may use Chinese.	May know some letter names or sounds; reads few or no words.	Copies, writes their name, or writes isolated words; may write in Chinese.
B Early acquisition	Understands simple, slow questions and instructions on familiar topics, with support.	Short phrases and simple sentences about familiar things; frequent errors.	Decodes simple words and short sentences; understands very simple texts with pictures.	Short simple sentences with familiar words; frequent errors in grammar and spelling; meaning mostly clear in short pieces.
C Developing competence	Follows most everyday talk and simple explanations; misses detail and implied meaning.	Connected sentences with "because", "but", "so"; errors common but meaning usually clear; everyday vocabulary.	Reads simple texts two or more years below age level with understanding; struggles with age-level texts.	A short connected piece; some joined sentences; errors frequent but rarely block meaning; basic punctuation.

Band	Listening	Speaking	Reading	Writing
D Competent	Follows most classroom talk at normal pace, including some implied meaning.	Speaks at length, explains and gives examples; occasional errors.	Reads age-level texts with some difficulty in vocabulary and inference.	Organised writing with a range of sentences; generally accurate with occasional errors; varied vocabulary.
E Fluent	Understands as a fluent speaker of the same age does.	Fluent and accurate for age.	Reads age-level texts as a fluent reader of the same age does.	Writing comparable to a fluent writer of the same age.

What E looks like at different ages. Years 1 and 2: talks in full sentences, reads simple books at the expected book band, writes simple sentences with phonically plausible spelling. Years 3 to 6: reads chapter books independently, writes organised paragraphs. Years 7 to 10: handles abstract talk and subject texts, writes extended, controlled, varied prose.

The overall English band is the band most of the four skills sit in. If one skill is two or more bands below the others (often writing), name it, because it needs its own support. Listening and speaking usually develop first; reading and writing for school subjects take longer. Research on second language learners (Cummins; Collier) suggests that everyday conversational English often develops within about two years, while the English needed for academic work often takes five years or more. Plan support accordingly.

7. Access rules and codes

Rule	English sections (listening, reading, writing, phonics, sentence reading)	Maths and science
Reading aloud	Only what the script says. Do not read reading texts aloud, explain words or translate. Instructions may be repeated in English.	Any question may be read aloud in English, as often as asked; point to the picture.
Chinese	Not used. Note what the student could say in Chinese, because it shows understanding.	If a Chinese-speaking colleague is present and the student cannot follow the English after it has been read aloud, the colleague may say the question once in Chinese. Mark it **L**. The mark still counts.
Answers in Chinese	Do not score, with one exception: in the two reading screens, a spoken answer to a question about what the student has just read counts if it shows understanding (mark **C**), because those questions test reading, not speaking.	Accepted in explanations; mark **L**.

Code	Meaning
NT	Not yet taught: the student says they have not learnt this. Scores 0; listed in the summary.
L	Language support given in a maths or science question. The number of L questions is evidence about English.
C	An answer given in Chinese: in the interview it does not count towards the speaking band; in the reading screens' questions it counts as understood.
R	In a listening task: the instruction was repeated once (as the script allows).
SC, **S**, **O**, **I**, **T**	Reading record codes: self-correction, substitution, omission, insertion, told.

Extra time, a reader or other access arrangements for a known need are allowed and recorded in the score summary.

8. Students from Chinese mainstream and bilingual schools

Age and grade. Placement is by age. A student joining UK Year N in September is the same age as a student starting Chinese Grade N minus 1, so they have usually **completed Chinese Grade N minus 2**.

Joining UK year	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
Same age as starting Chinese grade	K3 (大班)	G1	G2	G3	G4	G5	G6	G7 (初一)	G8 (初二)	G9 (初三)
Usually completed	K2	K3	G1	G2	G3	G4	G5	G6 (end of primary)	G7	G8

A student joining mid-year is partway through the next grade. Some families expect placement by Chinese grade, and some bilingual and international schools use "Grade 1" for children of 6 (UK Year 2). Explain the school's age rule early.

Maths. Calculation is usually strong and fast. Topics often met later in Chinese schools (PEP sequence; textbooks differ): times tables beyond 9 × 9, negative numbers (Grade 6), coordinates (Grade 7), ratio and percentages (Grade 6), Pythagoras (Grade 8), trigonometry and similar shapes (Grade 9). Roman numerals and imperial units are not taught. UK-style data handling and "explain your reasoning" questions are less familiar. Word problems in English are often the hardest part: compare the number problems with the word problems before deciding a student is weak at maths.

Science. Primary science covers broad topics. Secondary science splits into subjects: biology from 初一, physics from 初二, chemistry only in 初三. So a Year 8 entrant has usually done no secondary science, a Year 9 entrant some biology, and a Year 10 entrant biology and some physics but usually no chemistry. Mark NT and judge the student's scientific thinking from the working scientifically questions.

English. English is usually taught as a subject from Grade 3 (earlier in some cities), with strong vocabulary and grammar and less extended reading, writing and speaking. Many students learnt phonics (自然拼读) or the phonetic alphabet (音标) outside school, so some decode well but understand less than they can read aloud (the sentence reading screen's meaning checks show this). Common features of English from speakers of Chinese: missing plural -s, third person -s and past tense -ed; missing or extra "a" and "the"; l and r, n and l, v and w; th as s or f; light final consonants; pinyin letter values. These are normal stages of learning English and are not marked as reading errors when the word is clear.

From bilingual schools. English is often much stronger, but the curriculum may be a mix (for example Chinese national curriculum maths with English-medium science). Look at the reports for what was taught in English.

Typical patterns and what they mean.

Pattern	Likely meaning	Next step
Strong number problems, weak word problems	English barrier in maths	Read word problems aloud; English support; maths placement on number work
Good decoding (sentence reading age), weak meaning checks and reading paper	Phonics without vocabulary	Vocabulary-rich reading programme
Speaking well above writing	Typical for students from oral-heavy courses or immersion	Writing support
Low scores across English and maths, including taught topics, and slow progress through tasks	Could be a learning need, anxiety, tiredness or a bad day	Second short session or trial day before deciding; speak with the family
Very little speech in Chinese as well as English (young children)	Possible speech and language need	Raise gently with the family

9. Making the decision

Start with the **overall English band** and the **year group**, then adjust for maths and science, suitability and any needs. This is a guide for professional judgement and should be reviewed against the school's admissions policy and the support it can provide.

Overall English	Years 1 to 3	Years 4 to 6	Years 7 to 9	Year 10
A New to English	Usually offer with intensive English support: young children learn quickly in an English-speaking setting.	Offer with intensive English support if the school has capacity; review after one term.	Consider carefully. Offer only with an intensive English programme and a plan agreed with the family; expect a year or more before most lessons are fully accessible.	Direct entry to two-year IGCSE courses taught in English is not usually advisable. Consider a preparatory route if the school has one, or a later start.
B Early acquisition	Offer with timetabled English support.	Offer with timetabled English support.	Offer with timetabled English support and subject vocabulary support; review after six weeks.	Only with an English as a Second Language course, a reduced subject load and close review, if the school's policy allows.
C Developing competence	Offer with in-class support and monitoring.	Offer with in-class support and monitoring.	Offer with in-class support; monitor writing.	Offer with an English as a Second Language course and support for subject language.
D Competent	Offer.	Offer; monitor academic language.	Offer; monitor academic writing.	Offer; check English course level.
E Fluent	Offer.	Offer.	Offer.	Offer.

Then adjust

- **Maths and science band 3 or 4:** no change.
- **Band 2:** offer with a learning plan for the named topics (often the NT topics).
- **Band 1:** look first at NT and L. If the low score is explained by topics not yet taught or by English, treat it as band 2. If the student is low across taught content too, ask for further assessment before a decision.
- **Suitability:** any strand rated 1, or a serious mismatch between the family's expectations and the programme, goes to the head of section before any offer.
- **Special educational needs or disability:** follow the school's inclusion policy. A need is not in itself a reason to refuse a place; the question is what support the student needs and whether the school can provide it.
- **Safeguarding information** is handled by the Designated Safeguarding Lead and informs the support plan.
- **Uneven or surprising results** (for example strong listening but very weak reading, or a big gap between the reports and the assessment): find the reason; a second short session or a trial day often helps.

Telling the family. Start with the child's strengths. Explain any support in plain terms and how progress will be reviewed. If no offer is made, give the reason and, where possible, what would change the decision.

10. After an offer

- Copy the support plan (Candidate Summary, Section 5) to the homeroom teacher, the English support team and the head of section before the first day.
- Give the homeroom teacher the student's reading level (book band or reading age) and the English bands.
- Review the student after about six weeks against the plan.
- **Check the bands.** Once 20 to 30 students have joined, compare their assessment bands with how they are doing after one term, and adjust the maths and science band boundaries and the sentence reading guide if needed. The pack has not yet been standardised, so this local check matters.

11. Fairness, privacy and record keeping

- Use the same papers, timings and access rules for every candidate in a year group, so results are comparable.
- Keep papers and forms secure: they contain personal information about children. Store and share them under the school's data protection policy and China's Personal Information Protection Law (个人信息保护法), only with staff

who need them, and for the period the school's policy sets.

- Keep the papers confidential: do not send them home or let families photograph them, so they stay valid for future candidates. Vary the order or have a second version made if the same family applies for several children in the same year group.

12. Printing checklist (per candidate)

Years 1 to 3	Years 4 to 10
Student booklet for the year (print in colour if possible)	Student paper for the year
Assessor booklet for the year	Assessor booklet for the year
Early Reading Screen record sheets (cards and instructions: one set per room)	Sentence reading record (card: one laminated set per room)
Sentence reading record (card: one laminated set per room)	Interview record for the phase
Interview record for the phase	Parent conversation record
Parent conversation record	Candidate summary and decision
Candidate summary and decision	Homeroom teacher reference (sent before the visit)
Homeroom teacher reference (sent before the visit)	
Also: 20 counters (Years 1 and 2), crayons, pencils, rubber, a plain card to cover sentences, the levelled reading books (`01_Reading_Books_and_Materials`)	**Also:** pencils, rubber, ruler, a plain card to cover sentences, a clock or timer